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THURSDAY, 15 OCTOBER 2026

17 must-know stories, 19 Prelims facts, 22 editorials and 12 explainers, picked from 988 stories reported. Each item links to its source; notes quote the reports.

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MUST-KNOW

High-yield stories: make notes on these. Grouped by syllabus area.

Polity & Constitution

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court upholds Madras HC order quashing Tamil Nadu reservation notification for converts to Islam

The Supreme Court upheld the Madras High Court decision declaring that a person who has converted to Islam is not entitled to Backward Class reservation. A bench of Justices PK Mishra and Shree Chandrashekhar stated that individuals converting from the Hindu social order to a non-Hindu social order cannot claim affirmative action under Article 16(4). The court noted that backwardness suffered in an antecedent social order cannot be carried forward to confer backward class status in the new religion. The Tamil Nadu government had appealed against the High Court order that quashed its March 9, 2024 government order. The March 2024 Government Order allowed persons from backward classes, most backward classes, denotified communities, or scheduled castes to be treated as BC Muslims after converting to Islam. The GO aimed to issue community certificates for seven notified sects, ensuring that converts did not lose reservation benefits solely due to conversion. The High Court held that the GO violated judicial pronouncements and that religions like Islam and Christianity offer social equality, unlike the Hindu caste hierarchy.

When: 2026-10-15 · **Where:** Tamil Nadu · **Who:** Supreme Court, Madras High Court, Tamil Nadu Government, Sameer Ahamed · **Prelims:** The Supreme Court bench comprised Justices PK Mishra and Shree Chandrashekhar.; The disputed Tamil Nadu government order was issued on March 9, 2024.; The original petitioner who challenged the government order before the High Court was Sameer Ahamed.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Clarifies the constitutional limits of carrying forward pre-conversion social backwardness into non-Hindu religious communities.; Reaffirms judicial scrutiny on state executive orders creating special categories for reservation outside statutory frameworks.*

Static — Article 16(4) of the Constitution empowers the State to make provisions for the reservation of appointments or posts in favour of any backward class of citizens which is not adequately represented in the services under the State. The Constitution (Scheduled Castes) Order, 1950, originally restricted Scheduled Caste status to Hindus, later amended to include Sikhs (1956) and Buddhists (1990). Reservation policies in India are designed to remedy historical social discrimination and untouchability inherent in the traditional Hindu caste hierarchy.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment, Act/Bill/Rules

The Hindu: read the source · free copy on msn.com · also reported by Bar & Bench, NDTV Profit, India Today, Times of India, Fortune India, Reuters, LiveLaw, Kalkine India, The New Indian Express

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court to hear Waqf amendment case on November 4 after petitioners flag change in status of properties

The Supreme Court announced it will hear petitions challenging the validity of the Waqf (Amendment) Act, 2025, on November 4. A Bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi briefly heard the matter following concerns raised by petitioners. Petitioners flagged that the continued operation of the Act is leading to serious, permanent consequences regarding the status of waqf properties. Senior Advocate Nizam Pasha argued that the Limitation Act is now applicable, affecting properties if not defined within a specific period. Concerns were also raised that waqf-by-user and oral waqfs are no longer recognized, leading to irreversible changes in property status. The petitioners noted that multiple intervention applications are ballooning as parties seek to protect properties from losing their waqf character. In September 2025, a previous Bench had granted limited interim relief by staying some provisions while allowing others to operate. The Supreme Court allowed an intervention application filed by Shambir Singh and tagged it with the main batch of petitions for the November 4 hearing.

When: November 4 · **Who:** Supreme Court Bench led by CJI Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi; Senior Advocate Nizam Pasha · **Prelims:** The Supreme Court Bench scheduled the hearing for November 4.; Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi

heard the matter.; A previous Bench granted limited interim relief staying some provisions in September 2025.

Why it matters — *Highlights the judicial scrutiny of major legislative amendments affecting religious and charitable endowments in India.; Demonstrates the legal tension surrounding property rights, statutory limitations, and the traditional definitions of waqf.*

Static — Waqf properties in India are generally governed by the Waqf Act, which provides legal backing for the administration and protection of properties dedicated for religious or charitable purposes. The concept of waqf traditionally includes properties dedicated by use (waqf-by-user) or oral declaration, alongside formal deeds. The Supreme Court of India holds the power of judicial review under Article 13 and Article 32 to examine the constitutional validity of parliamentary legislations.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment, Act/Bill/Rules

Bar & Bench: read the source · also reported by Hindustan Times, LawChakra

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Cabinet decides to file an appeal before SC against HC order that struck down law to increase reservation for SC/STs beyond 50%

The Karnataka High Court struck down the 2022 law that increased SC/ST reservations, ruling it violated the 50 percent ceiling. The 2022 law raised SC quota from 15% to 17% and ST quota from 3% to 7%, taking total reservation to 56%. A Division Bench declared Sections 3 and 4 of the Act unconstitutional for violating Articles 14, 15, and 16. The court held that population size or inadequate representation does not permit the state to breach the 50 percent limit. The Bench ruled that the state failed to mandatorily consult the National Commissions for SCs and STs prior to enactment. The state government decided to file an appeal in the Supreme Court against the High Court order. Leaders urged the Union government to review the 50 percent ceiling and include the law in the Ninth Schedule.

When: October 2026 · **Where:** Karnataka · **Who:** Karnataka High Court, Karnataka Cabinet, National Commission for Scheduled Castes, National Commission for Scheduled Tribes · **Prelims:** The 2022 law increased the SC quota from 15% to 17% and the ST quota from 3% to 7%.; The overall reservation in Karnataka rose from 50% to 56% under the struck-down law.; The Karnataka High Court Bench was led by Chief Justice Vibhu Bakhru and Justice KS Hemalekha.

Why it matters — *Tests the limits of state legislative power in expanding affirmative action beyond the judicial 50 percent ceiling.; Highlights procedural mandates like prior consultation with constitutional bodies such as NCSC and NCST.*

Static — The 50 percent reservation ceiling was established by a nine-judge Supreme Court Bench in the 1992 Indra Sawhney case. Articles 15(4) and 16(4) of the Constitution empower the state to make special provisions for the advancement of backward classes. Articles 338(9) and 338A(9) mandate consultation with the National Commissions for SC and ST respectively on major policy matters.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution, Social Justice & Welfare, Governance & Policy

The Hindu: read the source · free copy on thenewsminute.com

Governance & Policy

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Renaming of National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP)

The Union Cabinet approved the proposal of the Department of Rural Development to continue the National Social Assistance Programme under the new name Pradhan Mantri Samajik Sahayata Yojana. The scheme is continued for a duration of five years from 2026-27 to 2030-31 with a total budgetary outlay of Rs. 53,428 crore. The core objective is to provide a minimum level of social security and financial assistance to vulnerable sections including the elderly, widows, and persons with disabilities. A total of 3.20 crore beneficiaries across all 36 States and Union Territories will benefit from the approved continuation and revisions. The eligibility criterion for benchmark disability under the scheme has been revised from 80% to 40%. The minimum age criterion for the disability pension is now set as since birth. The amount of assistance under the divyangjan pension scheme is revised to Rs. 375 for ages 0-79 years and Rs. 625 for 80 years and above. Pension schemes for old-aged persons, widows, and the family benefit scheme will continue in their existing forms.

When: 2026-10-15 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Union Cabinet, Department of Rural Development · **Prelims:** Original launch date of NSAP: 15th August 1995; Total budgetary outlay: Rs. 53,428 crore; Duration of the scheme: 2026-27 to 2030-31

Why it matters — *Expands inclusivity by lowering the benchmark disability requirement from 80% to 40%.; Ensures continued financial support for 3.20 crore vulnerable beneficiaries across all States and UTs.*

Static — The National Social Assistance Programme was originally launched on 15th August 1995 as a Centrally Sponsored Scheme. The nodal ministry responsible for the implementation of the scheme is the Ministry of Rural Development. The programme is aligned with the Directive Principles of State Policy enshrined under Article 41 of the Constitution of India.

Syllabus: GS2: Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Scheme

ForumIAS: read the source · also reported by Hindustan Times, Kashmir Observer, Insights on India

GS2 MAKE NOTES

PAC grills Centre, States on ‘fraud markers’ flagged by CAG in SC scholarship schemes

The Public Accounts Committee held a parliamentary hearing questioning Ministry officials on the delayed submission of audit compliance reports. The Public Accounts Committee questioned the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment over delayed action-taken reports regarding CAG-flagged fraud markers in SC scholarship schemes. Committee Members question the Secretary, Social Justice and Empowerment Ministry, on why action-taken reports against points highlighted in the CAG audit had not been submitted; Ministry assures panel that the reports will be submitted in a month’s time

When: 2026-10-15 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** Public Accounts Committee, Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment · **Prelims:** The committee questioned the Secretary of the Social Justice and Empowerment Ministry.; The Ministry assured the panel that action-taken reports will be submitted in a month.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights systemic administrative delays in addressing financial irregularities in welfare schemes.; Reinforces the oversight role of parliamentary committees over the executive branch.*

Static — The Public Accounts Committee is a parliamentary committee set up first in 1921 under the Montague-Chelmsford Reforms and presently under Rule 308 of Lok Sabha Rules of Procedure. PAC consists of 22 members: 15 from Lok Sabha and 7 from Rajya Sabha, elected for a term of one year using proportional representation. The chairperson of the PAC is appointed by the Speaker of the Lok Sabha and conventionally belongs to the principal opposition party since 1967.

Syllabus: GS2: Governance & Policy, Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Scheme, Report/Index

The Hindu: read the source

International Relations

GS2 MAKE NOTES

India, US lock first phase of trade pact; legal drafting underway: Piyush Goyal

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal announced that the first phase of the India-US trade pact has been finalized. The pact is currently undergoing final legal drafting before it is signed and operationalized. India aims to operationalize the agreement once it secures a competitive advantage over peer countries. The announcement addresses speculation about delays in the US trade deal despite convergence on tariffs and manufacturing overcapacity. Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal stated that talks are progressing well and will align with the US tariff structure outcomes under Section 301. Separately, Goyal stated that the free trade agreement between India and the European Union will be inked in December and take effect by February or March. Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman previously noted that talks had reached a plateau, while US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer stated a deal is in final stages but not imminent.

When: 2026-10-15 · **Where:** New Delhi, India · **Who:** Piyush Goyal, Rajesh Agrawal, Nirmala Sitharaman, Jamieson Greer · **Prelims:** Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal announced the finalization of the first phase of the India-US trade pact.; The India-EU free trade agreement is slated to be signed in December and come into force by February or March.; Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal mentioned parallel work in the US regarding tariff structures under Section 301.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Clarifies the state of bilateral trade negotiations between India and the United States amidst external speculation.; Indicates progress on India's broader trade strategy, including the upcoming India-EU free trade agreement.*

Static — Bilateral trade agreements involve negotiations between two sovereign nations to reduce or eliminate tariffs and non-tariff barriers, boosting mutual trade. Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974 permits the US Trade Representative to investigate foreign trade practices and impose tariffs or retaliatory measures. Free Trade Agreements (FTAs) cover trade in goods and services, investment, and intellectual property rights to deepen economic integration between partner countries.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

Economic Times: read the source · free copy on deccanchronicle.com · also reported by BusinessLine, The Hindu

Economy

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Govt launches semiconductor scheme targeting full chip value chain, Semicon 2.0 projects

Chief minister Joseph Vijay launched the Tamil Nadu Semiconductor Ecosystem Scheme to provide additional incentives for projects approved under Semicon India 2.0. The programme targets the entire semiconductor value chain, covering design, chip fabrication, assembly, testing, packaging, equipment, raw materials, and R&D. The scheme focuses on providing financial incentives for projects selected under the national semiconductor programme and backing strategic investments for the state ecosystem. The initiative aims to help Tamil Nadu emerge as a key semiconductor and advanced electronics hub while generating employment for the youth. The state government previously announced plans to set up a semiconductor and electronics manufacturing park at Maduramangalam in Kancheepuram district. State industries minister S Keerthana earlier announced plans during the assembly session to provide additional incentives for Semicon 2.0 projects. Specific details regarding the financial incentives and structural framework of the newly launched scheme are not known at this point.

When: 2026-10-15 · **Where:** Tamil Nadu, Maduramangalam, Kancheepuram district · **Who:** Joseph Vijay, S Keerthana · **Prelims:** Tamil Nadu Semiconductor Ecosystem Scheme targets the entire semiconductor value chain.; A semiconductor and electronics manufacturing park is planned at Maduramangalam in Kancheepuram district.; S Keerthana serves as the state industries minister of Tamil Nadu.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Positions Tamil Nadu as a competitive destination for advanced electronics and chip manufacturing investments.; Aims to create specialized high-tech employment opportunities for the youth in the state.*

Static — India's national semiconductor mission aims to build a vibrant semiconductor and display ecosystem to enable India to emerge as a global hub for electronics manufacturing. Semiconductor fabrication plants require massive capital investments, highly specialized infrastructure, continuous power supply, and millions of gallons of ultra-pure water daily. The semiconductor value chain begins with silicon extraction and design, moves to wafer fabrication, and ends with packaging, testing, and final electronic product integration.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Science & Technology, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Scheme

timesofindia.indiatimes.com: read the source

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Current account deficit narrows to $5.2 billion in August: RBI data

India's current account deficit narrowed to USD 5.2 billion in August 2026 from USD 6.1 billion a year ago. The reduction was aided by a lower merchandise trade deficit and higher surpluses in services trade. The core issue highlights India's external sector stability, balancing trade flows, services growth, and capital inflows. The net deficit in the merchandise trade account declined to USD 26.6 billion in August from USD 27.6 billion last year. Merchandise exports rose to USD 44.7 billion and imports increased to USD 71.3 billion in August. The surplus in services trade increased to USD 16.5 billion, with exports at USD 35.5 billion. Net foreign direct investment inflows stood at USD 3.3 billion, compared with a net outflow of USD 0.1 billion a year ago. The overall balance of payments recorded a surplus of USD 45.4 billion in August, compared with a deficit of USD 5.6 billion last year.

When: August 2026 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Reserve Bank of India · **Prelims:** Current account deficit in August 2026 stood at USD 5.2 billion.; Merchandise exports in August 2026 reached USD 44.7 billion.; Services trade surplus in August 2026 rose to USD 16.5 billion.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Reflects the robustness of India's external trade and services sector.; Demonstrates turnaround in foreign capital inflows including FDI and FPI.*

Static — The current account measures the flow of goods, services, and transfers between a country and the rest of the world. The Reserve Bank of India compiles and releases data on India's Balance of Payments and current account developments. Merchandise trade deficit represents the excess of merchandise imports over merchandise exports.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy

Business Standard: read the source · *free copy on ptinews.com*

GS3 MAKE NOTES

IMF applauds India’s GDP data revamp, says country entered energy shock with strong fundamentals

The International Monetary Fund praised India for entering a global energy shock with robust economic fundamentals and fiscal prudence. IMF Asia and Pacific Department Director Krishna Srinivasan stated that exchange rate pressures reflect global factors rather than economic failure. The IMF raised India's growth forecast to 7 percent for this year and next, with calendar-year figures at 7.4 percent for 2026 and 7.0 percent for 2027. Real GDP growth reached 7.8 percent in the April-June quarter, according to the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI). Srinivasan confirmed that India's GDP data revision with a 2022-23 base year is entirely consistent with IMF guidelines and good practices. The World Economic Outlook positioned India among the fastest-growing major economies, driven by resilient domestic demand and robust services. India is noted as a major economy that does not need extra fiscal consolidation beyond current plans to maintain its 2025 debt ratio. Regional Asian growth is projected to moderate, while downside risks include Middle Eastern tensions and El Nino pressures. The IMF highlighted four core reform priorities for India: tackling youth unemployment, strengthening social protection, improving energy security, and deepening regional integration.

When: 2026-10-15 · **Where:** Bangkok · **Who:** Krishna Srinivasan, International Monetary Fund (IMF), Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) · **Prelims:** IMF projected India's growth at 7 percent for this year and next, and 6.9 percent over the medium term.; Real GDP growth for the April-June quarter reached 7.8 percent according to MoSPI.; India's new GDP series uses 2022-23 as the base year.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Validates India's economic statistical methodologies against international standards.; Positions India as one of the fastest-growing major economies despite global volatility and energy shocks.*

Static — The International Monetary Fund (IMF) is an international organization of 190 member countries, working to foster global monetary cooperation, secure financial stability, and promote sustainable economic growth. Gross Domestic Product (GDP) base year revisions are periodically undertaken by countries to reflect structural changes in the economy, update consumption baskets, and improve data accuracy. The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) is the nodal agency in India responsible for official statistical data collection, processing, and dissemination including GDP calculations.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, International Relations · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

Economic Times: read the source · *free copy on businesstoday.in* · *also reported by BusinessLine, India Today*

GS3 MAKE NOTES

India Rolls Out Seven New BIS Standards, Including For EVs, Robotics And Healthcare; Launches Silver Refinery Certification Scheme

The government launched these standards to regulate emerging industrial sectors and enhance quality control in manufacturing. India introduced seven new Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) norms for electric vehicles, robotics, and healthcare, alongside a certification scheme for silver refineries.

When: 2026-10-15 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Bureau of Indian Standards · **Prelims:** Seven new BIS standards were rolled out.; Sectors covered include EVs, robotics, and healthcare.; A Silver Refinery Certification Scheme was launched.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Ensures consumer safety and product reliability in high-tech sectors like electric vehicles and robotics.; Enhances transparency and quality in the precious metals market through the silver refinery certification.*

Static — The Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) is the National Standards Body of India established under the Bureau of Indian Standards Act, 2016. BIS functions under the aegis of the Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, Government of India. It is responsible for the harmonious development of the activities of standardization, marking and quality certification of goods.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Science & Technology, Governance & Policy, Infrastructure & Energy · Prelims angle: Scheme

Swarajya: read the source

GS3 MAKE NOTES

FDI windfall as Cabinet clears 60.7% IDBI stake sale to Canada’s Fairfax

The Union Cabinet approved the sale of a 60.72% stake in IDBI Bank to a subsidiary of Canada-based Fairfax Financial Holdings. The strategic sale was cleared by the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The total transaction value for the 60.72% stake sale is Rs 52,878.08 crore. The transaction comprises the sale of the central government's 30.48% stake and Life Insurance Corporation of India's 30.24% holding in the bank. Post-transaction, the government will retain a 15% stake and LIC will hold 19%, bringing their combined holding to 34%. Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw stated that once completed, this will be the largest foreign direct investment in India's financial sector.

When: 2026-10-15 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Union Cabinet, CCEA, Fairfax Financial Holdings, Government of India, LIC, Ashwini Vaishnaw · **Prelims:** The stake being sold in IDBI Bank to Fairfax is 60.72%.; The total value of the transaction is Rs 52,878.08 crore.; The government is selling 30.48% and LIC is selling 30.24% of their holdings.

> ***Why it matters —*** *It marks the largest foreign direct investment in India's financial sector upon completion.; It advances the government's strategic disinvestment and privatization agenda for public sector banking assets.*

Static — Fairfax Financial Holdings is a Canadian holding company based in Toronto, engaged in property and casualty insurance, reinsurance, and investment management. IDBI Bank Limited was initially established in 1964 as the Industrial Development Bank of India under an Act of Parliament to provide credit for industrial growth. In 2004, IDBI was transformed into a commercial bank, and it was later categorized as a private sector bank by the RBI after LIC acquired a controlling stake.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, International Relations

msn.com: read the source · also reported by Hindustan Times, India TV News

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Women, Work and Enterprise: India’s Push for Better Livelihoods

A PIB backgrounder highlighted significant gains in female labour force participation and worker population ratios based on Periodic Labour Force Survey data. Periodic Labour Force Survey data shows female Labour Force Participation Rate rose to 40.0% in 2025 from 23.3% in 2017-18. India's female employment policy is shifting focus toward quality, formalisation, and enterprise support. India’s women employment story is moving from participation to better-quality work. Building on this improvement, policy support is strengthening women’s work through formal enterprise recognition, credit, market access, safer workplaces, skilling and new livelihood avenues. Now, the focus is on turning higher participation into stronger income, security and economic development. Rising Women’s Employment and Expanding Economic Opportunities Women’s employment in India is moving beyond presence alone.

When: 2025 (reported on 2026-10-15) · **Where:** India · **Who:** Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (PLFS data) · **Prelims:** Female LFPR (aged 15+) increased from 23.3% in 2017-18 to 40.0% in 2025.; Female WPR increased from 22.0% in 2017-18 to 38.8% in 2025.; An estimated 20 crore women aged 15 and above were employed in India in 2025.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Demonstrates a quantitative recovery and expansion in women's engagement within the national labour market.; Highlights the policy pivot from simple workforce absorption to improving employment quality, social security, and enterprise growth.*

Static — The Periodic Labour Force Survey is conducted by the National Sample Survey Office under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation since April 2017. Labour Force Participation Rate is the percentage of the working-age population aged 15 years and above that is either employed or actively seeking work. Worker Population Ratio is defined as the percentage of employed persons within the total working-age population.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Social Justice & Welfare · Prelims angle: Report/Index

PIB: read the source

GS3 MAKE NOTES

The cumulative exports (merchandise & services) during April-September 2026-27 are estimated at US$ 476.20 Billion, as compared to US$ 418.31 Billion in April-September 2025-26, an estimated growth of 13.84%.

The Ministry of Commerce and Industry released the monthly trade data estimates for September 2026 and the half-yearly cumulative figures. India's total exports for the April-September period of 2026-27 reached US$ 476.20 billion, marking a 13.84 percent growth compared to the previous year. India’s total exports (Merchandise and Services combined) for September 2026* are estimated at US$ 80.75 Billion, registering a positive growth of 10.99 percent vis-à-vis September 2025. Table 1: Trade during September 2026* September 2026 (US$ Billion) September 2025 (US$ Billion) Merchandise Exports 44.40 36.08 Imports 74.61 69.08 Services* Exports 36.35 36.67 Imports 19.44 17.84 Total Trade (Merchandise +Services) * Exports 80.75 72.76 Imports 94.05 86.93 Trade Balance -13.30 -14.17 * Note: The latest data for services sec

When: April-September 2026-27 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Ministry of Commerce and Industry · **Prelims:** Cumulative exports for April-September 2026-27 are estimated at US$ 476.20 billion.; Total imports for April-September 2026-27 are estimated at US$ 551.13 billion.; Trade balance for April-September 2026-27 stands at minus US$ 74.93 billion.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Reflects the trajectory of India's external trade and global economic integration.; Provides essential indicators for macroeconomic stability and foreign exchange reserves management.*

Static — Foreign Trade Policy guides India's export and import policies, managed by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry. Merchandise trade data is compiled by the Directorate General of Commercial Intelligence and Statistics (DGCI&S). Services trade data is released periodically by the Reserve Bank of India as part of the Balance of Payments data.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

PIB: read the source · also reported by Economic Times

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Strat360PL Report Charts India's Path to a Deeper Electronics & Semiconductor Industry

The report was recently published, offering new insights and recommendations for India's semiconductor ecosystem. The Strat360PL report outlines a strategic roadmap for developing a deeper and more robust electronics and semiconductor manufacturing industry in India.

When: 2026-10-15 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Strat360PL · **Prelims:** The report is titled Strat360PL.; It focuses on India's electronics and semiconductor industry.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Crucial for achieving technological self-reliance and reducing import dependencies in critical electronic components.; Helps position India as a trusted global hub for semiconductor design and manufacturing.*

Static — Semiconductor manufacturing involves complex fabrication processes using silicon wafers to create integrated circuits used in electronic devices. India launched the Semicon India Programme with a multi-billion dollar fiscal support package to attract global semiconductor and display manufacturing units. The India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) was established as a specialized business division within Digital India Corporation to drive the country's strategy.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Science & Technology · Prelims angle: Report/Index

India's News.Net: read the source

Environment & Ecology

GS3 MAKE NOTES

India’s Ramsar Site tally reaches 103 with addition of Sukhna Wetland (Chandigarh) and Sauj Jheel (UP)

Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav announced that India's Ramsar site tally has reached 103. Sukhna Lake in Chandigarh and Sauj Jheel in Uttar Pradesh are the latest wetlands designated as Ramsar sites. The inclusion highlights the government's commitment to wetland conservation, biodiversity, and climate security. The new designations aim to sustain local livelihoods and enhance ecological benefits of wetland ecosystems. Union Minister Bhupender Yadav congratulated Uttar Pradesh and Chandigarh for achieving this milestone. The Minister invited travellers and tourists to visit Sukhna and Sauj to explore their natural beauty.

When: 2026-10-15 · **Where:** Chandigarh and Uttar Pradesh · **Who:** Bhupender Yadav, Union Minister for Environment, Forest and Climate Change · **Prelims:** India's Ramsar site tally has reached 103.; Sukhna Wetland is located in Chandigarh.; Sauj Jheel is located in Uttar Pradesh.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Marks a significant milestone in India's target to expand and protect its ecologically sensitive wetland areas.; Boosts local livelihoods, climate security, and biodiversity conservation in Chandigarh and Uttar Pradesh.*

Static — The Ramsar Convention is an intergovernmental treaty signed in 1971 in Ramsar, Iran, for the conservation and wise use of wetlands. It is the only global environmental treaty dedicated to a specific ecosystem, focusing on wetlands as habitats for waterbirds. India is a contracting party to the Ramsar Convention, having signed it in 1982, and undertakes steps to designate wetlands of international importance.

Syllabus: GS3: Environment & Ecology, Geography, Education · Prelims angle: Place in news

PIB: read the source · free copy on newsonair.gov.in · also reported by The Tribune, Business Upturn, Jagran Josh

GS3 MAKE NOTES

State of the World's Forests 2026 Report, Key Findings, Progress & Challenges

The FAO released the State of the World's Forests 2026 report, highlighting global forest restoration progress and a target to restore 470 million hectares by 2030. The report was triggered by the need to assess global forest health, governance, and socioeconomic contributions using data from FRA 2025 and KMGBF. The core debate centers on transitioning from isolated afforestation projects to holistic, multifunctional landscape recovery while overcoming significant data and financing gaps. Global forests span 4.14 billion hectares, holding 714 gigatonnes of carbon and supporting up to 80% of terrestrial biodiversity, but face widespread degradation. Over 1.56 billion hectares of terrestrial land are degraded globally, including 460 million hectares of forest land, alongside historical deforestation of 489 million hectares. Natural disturbances affect vast areas annually, with wildfires impacting 127 million hectares and pest infestations and diseases damaging at least 50 million hectares. A major 2030 restoration deficit exists because only 44 million hectares are actively reported under restoration against global pledges exceeding 1 billion hectares. India ranks first worldwide in total forest area under active restoration reported to FRA 2025 with 9.8 million hectares, ahead of China and Ethiopia.

When: 2026 · **Where:** Global · **Who:** Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) · **Prelims:** Forests span 4.14 billion hectares, representing approximately 32% of the global land area.; India leads the world in reported active forest restoration under FRA 2025 with 9.8 million hectares.; Wildfires affect around 127 million hectares of forests annually.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights India's global leadership in forest restoration, ranking first with 9.8 million hectares under active restoration reported to FRA 2025.; Identifies critical global challenges including a 470-million-hectare restoration deficit and mounting climate-induced natural disturbances like wildfires and pest infestations.*

Static — The Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) is a specialized agency of the United Nations that leads international efforts to defeat hunger and promote sustainable forestry and agriculture. The State of the World's Forests (SOFO) is the FAO's biennial flagship assessment monitoring the extent, health, governance, and socioeconomic contributions of global forest ecosystems. The Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework (KMGBF), adopted under the Convention on Biological Diversity, sets global targets including halting biodiversity loss and restoring degraded ecosystems by 2030.

Syllabus: GS3: Environment & Ecology, Agriculture & Allied · Prelims angle: Report/Index

Vajiram & Ravi: read the source · free copy on insightsonindia.com

Defence

GS3 MAKE NOTES

MoD inks Rs 4,106 crore contracts for GSAT-7C communication satellite and Varunastra Heavy Weight Torpedoes

The Ministry of Defence signed contracts worth approximately Rs 4,106 crore for the GSAT-7C communication satellite and Varunastra Heavy Weight Torpedoes. The contracts aim to boost the operational capabilities of the Indian Air Force and the Indian Navy respectively. The agreements support domestic defence manufacturing and align with the Aatmanirbhar Bharat and Make-in-India vision. The Rs 2,563 crore contract for the GSAT-7C satellite was signed with New Space India Limited in Bengaluru. The satellite will provide secure, resilient, and seamless communication capabilities for Indian Air Force assets. The Rs 1,543 crore contract for Varunastra torpedoes was inked with Bharat Dynamics Limited in Hyderabad. Varunastra is an indigenous ship-launched anti-submarine torpedo developed by the Naval Science and Technological Laboratory. The contracts were signed in New Delhi on October 15, 2026, in the presence of Additional Secretary and Director General A Anbarasu.

When: October 15, 2026 · **Where:** New Delhi, Bengaluru, Hyderabad · **Who:** Ministry of Defence, New Space India Limited, Bharat Dynamics Limited, A Anbarasu · **Prelims:** Total contract value is approximately Rs 4,106 crore.; GSAT-7C contract value is Rs 2,563 crore with New Space India Limited, Bengaluru.; Varunastra contract value is Rs 1,543 crore with Bharat Dynamics Limited, Hyderabad.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Enhances secure communication capabilities for the Indian Air Force.; Improves anti-submarine warfare capabilities of the Indian Navy.*

Static — New Space India Limited (NSIL) is a central public sector enterprise under the Department of Space, Government of India, incorporated to commercialise space research products. Bharat Dynamics Limited (BDL) is a public sector undertaking under the Ministry of Defence, manufacturing guided missiles and allied defence equipment in India. Naval Science and Technological Laboratory (NSTL) is a premier naval research laboratory under the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO).

Syllabus: GS3: Defence, Science & Technology, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Data/Stats, Agreement/MoU

PIB: read the source · free copy on news.webindia123.com · also reported by Media India Group

PRELIMS FACTS

Concrete developments worth a quick read: exercises, pacts, Acts, approvals, schemes, species, verdicts.

GOVERNANCE & POLICY | AGREEMENT/MOU | QUICK READ

Digital India BHASHINI Division and Government of Manipur Sign MoU to Advance Multilingual AI and Language Technology at BHASHINI Rajyam Workshop

The Digital India BHASHINI Division and the Government of Manipur signed a Memorandum of Understanding to advance multilingual artificial intelligence and deploy regional language technology on public digital platforms. The MoU was signed during the BHASHINI Rajyam Workshop in Imphal, organised jointly by the division and the state Department of Information Technology.

PIB: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY | SCHEME | REPORT/INDEX | QUICK READ

Keralam to decide on PM SHRI scheme after sub-committee report: Minister Samsudheen

General Education Minister N Samsudheen stated in the Assembly that Keralam will decide on the PM SHRI scheme after a sub-committee submits its report. The state faces a crisis because the previous Left government signed an MoU agreeing to implement the scheme without any withdrawal provision.

Hindustan Times: source

ECONOMY | SCHEME | QUICK READ

Tamil Nadu launches semiconductor scheme with customised investment incentives

Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay launched the Tamil Nadu Semiconductor Ecosystem Scheme at the secretariat to attract chip investments. The scheme aims to position Tamil Nadu as a leading hub for advanced electronics manufacturing and wafer fabrication. It offers additional financial incentives over and above central assistance to support companies investing in the sector.

newindianexpress.com: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY | SCHEME | QUICK READ

DDWS Organised 13th District Collectors' Peyjal Samvad to Strengthen Community Ownership, Source Sustainability and Service Delivery under Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0

The Department of Drinking Water & Sanitation (DDWS), Ministry of Jal Shakti, organised the 13 th edition of the District Collectors' Peyjal Samvad today through video conferencing, bringing together senior officials, District Collectors/ District Magistrates, and Mission Directors of State/UTs to deliberate on accelerating the implementation of Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM) 2.0 and sharing of best practices.

PIB: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY | ACT/BILL/RULES | QUICK READ

Kerala Assembly unanimously passes resolution asking Union government to accept State's revised ESA proposal

The Kerala Legislative Assembly unanimously passed a resolution requesting the Centre to accept the state's revised Ecologically Sensitive Area proposal. The revised proposal seeks to exempt an area of 8,590.69 square kilometres across 98 revenue villages from the Western Ghats ESA. The resolution was moved by Minister for Electricity, Environment and Parliamentary Affairs Sunny Joseph in the state assembly.

The Hindu: source

ECONOMY | SCHEME | QUICK READ

Bank deposits hit record $3 trillion, boosted by dollar deposits scheme

India's banking system deposits reached a record high of around 284 trillion rupees ($2.99 trillion) in the second half of September. The surge was driven by the Reserve Bank of India's discounted swap window, which was introduced to attract foreign-currency dollar deposits. The core issue involves banks building funding buffers and trying to match credit growth that is outpacing deposit growth.

Business Standard: source

ECONOMY | REPORT/INDEX | QUICK READ

Press Note on Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) Monthly Bulletin September 2026

The release of the official monthly bulletin for September 2026 by the ministry. The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation released the Periodic Labour Force Survey monthly bulletin for September 2026.

PIB: source

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY | SCHEME | REPORT/INDEX | QUICK READ

IIT Madras Launches Brain Mapping Mission, Unveils World's First Stroke Atlas

IIT Madras launched a mission to create three-dimensional atlases of over 100 human brains at cellular resolution across the lifespan. Prime Minister Narendra Modi dedicated the Sudha Gopalakrishnan Brain Centre at IIT Madras to the nation on October 11. The initiative includes the release of C-STROKE, recognized as the world's first human ischemic stroke atlas.

NDTV: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY | SCHEME | QUICK READ

Union Home Minister Shri Amit Shah addresses, via video conference, a ceremony for distribution of assistive devices to Divyangs including those affected by Naxal violence, under the ongoing ‘Seva Sankalp Abhiyan’, marking the completion of 25 years of Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi’s Seva and Samarpan

Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation Shri Amit Shah today addressed, via video conference, an assistive devices distribution ceremony for Divyangjans, including those affected by Naxal violence, under the ongoing ‘ Seva Sankalp Abhiyan ’ , being organised to mark 25 years of Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi ’ s Seva and Samarpan .

PIB: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS | REPORT/INDEX | QUICK READ

India asks when UN body will report on PoK human rights concerns

India questioned the UN human rights body at the UNGA Third Committee session about when it will report on Pakistan's steps regarding the dire situation in PoK. First Secretary Anuj Swarup highlighted issues including killings by armed forces, internet restrictions, and detained leaders of the Joint Awami Action Committee.

The Hindu: source

DEFENCE | QUICK READ

Defence Ministry approves over Rs. 2,400 crore procurement from startups and MSMEs

The recent approval by the Defence Ministry to procure equipment from domestic startups and MSMEs put the topic in the news. The Defence Ministry approved defence procurement worth over Rs. 2,400 crore from domestic startups and micro, small, and medium enterprises. India is expanding domestic defence manufacturing, with thousands of smaller enterprises supporting the sector and exports reaching nearly 100 countries.

BusinessLine: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION | JUDGMENT | ACT/BILL/RULES | QUICK READ

Fees for entire professional course must be notified before admission: Supreme Court

The Supreme Court ruled that fees for the entire duration of a professional course must be fixed before admission and cannot be altered mid-course. The judgment stemmed from appeals by private engineering colleges against a Calcutta High Court ruling that barred mid-course fee hikes. The case involved B.Tech students of the 2023-27 batch whose fees were hiked after a West Bengal government notification issued in October 2023.

Bar & Bench: source

ECONOMY | QUICK READ

India may hike fuel prices in November, pushing inflation above RBI target: Oxford Economist

The Indian government may moderately hike fuel prices in November ahead of state assembly elections planned for early next year. Oxford Economics notes that November is the final realistic window for pump price increases before election campaigning intensifies. States going to the polls next year include Goa, Uttarakhand, Punjab, Manipur, Uttar Pradesh, Himachal Pradesh, and Gujarat.

Mint: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION | QUICK READ

Special summary revision of poll roll in 17 states

The Election Commission directed 17 States and Union Territories to conduct a Special Summary Revision of electoral rolls with 1st January next year as the qualifying date. The directive follows previous instructions issued on 29th September to undertake a special drive for enrolling left-out, young, and first-time eligible electors. The core issue focuses on maintaining clean electoral rolls while ensuring maximum participation of eligible citizens without letting ineligible persons remain.

Times of India: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY | SPECIES | QUICK READ

Waste Management in India's Tiger Reserves: New Guidelines

The guidelines were released in response to growing environmental concerns over mounting waste in protected wildlife habitats. The government has issued new guidelines to streamline waste management and reduce pollution inside India's tiger reserves.

See Positive: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY | QUICK READ

NITI Aayog Data Center Policy Archives

The policy archives serve as a reference point for evolving digital infrastructure and data storage regulations. NITI Aayog maintains archives relating to data center policies to guide the expansion of digital infrastructure in India.

Insights on India: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY QUICK READ

Union Cabinet approves Rs 2,000 crore bonus for 11 lakh railway staff

The Union Cabinet approved a productivity-linked bonus equivalent to 78 days wages worth Rs 2,009.61 crore for about 11 lakh railway employees. The bonus payment is made annually to eligible railway staff before the Dussehra and Diwali holidays. The Cabinet also extended the National Social Assistance Programme for five more years until 2030-31 with a financial outlay of Rs 53,428 crore.

newindianexpress.com: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION APPOINTMENT JUDGMENT QUICK READ

BJP leader Braj Mohan Ram sworn in as Odisha Governor

President Droupadi Murmu appointed Braj Mohan Ram as the new Governor of Odisha. Braj Mohan Ram succeeds Hari Babu Kambhampati in the gubernatorial office. He hails from the Palamu district in Jharkhand and previously headed the BJP's Scheduled Caste Morcha in Jharkhand. He served as a Member of Parliament for the Palamu Lok Sabha constituency for three terms, winning in 1996, 1998, and 1999.

The Hindu: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY REPORT/INDEX QUICK READ

MP Air Pollution Under NGT Scanner Ahead Of Winter, Tribunal Seeks Action Report In Two Weeks; Bhopal PM10

The National Green Tribunal Central Zone Bench in Bhopal directed concerned departments to submit detailed replies on air pollution control measures within two weeks. The tribunal stressed strict compliance with Central Pollution Control Board guidelines, state regulations, and Supreme Court orders, particularly during upcoming festivals. The applicant's advocate confirmed the bench called for enforcement of the Graded Response Action Plan with corrective measures based on air quality levels.

freepressjournal.in: source

EDITORIAL WATCH

What the opinion pages argued: two or three lines each.

GS3 Mint Quick Edit | Wholesale inflation heating up lends weight to the case for another policy rate hike

The editorial argues that rising wholesale inflation necessitates potential interest rate hikes by the RBI alongside cautious fiscal management by the government. With India’s wholesale price index (WPI) showing inflation of 11.4% last month (and the retail rate at 5.5%), it’s clear that price stability needs attention. RBI might go for another rate hike but the Centre should be cautious with tools at its disposal.

Mint

GS3 ‘Innovate Today, Nourish Tomorrow’ for Food Security

World Food Day on October 16, 2026, carries the theme 'Innovate Today, Nourish Tomorrow' to highlight global hunger crises and unaffordable healthy diets. In 2025, approximately 645 million people faced hunger globally, while one-third of the world population could not afford healthy diets. The core issue is moving beyond mere calorie availability to ensure affordability, nutritional security, climate resilience, and reduced post-harvest food losses. India's foodgrain production reached 376.56 million tonnes in 2025-26, and agricultural exports hit a record $52.55 billion.

The Hindu

GS2 A split verdict, faltering remedies and people’s power

A two-judge Supreme Court Bench in Dr. Jaya Thakur vs Union of India delivered a split verdict on the 2023 Act governing the appointment of the CEC and ECs. The core issue is that the 2023 Act gives appointment power to a panel dominated by the Prime Minister and a Union Minister, overriding the Baranwal ruling. Justice Dipankar Datta held the Act must be tested against the Baranwal judgment, while Justice Satish Chandra Sharma referred the matter to a Constitution Bench.

The Hindu

GS2 A contested UNSC seat poses a test for India

India has launched its bid for a non-permanent seat on the United Nations Security Council for the 2028-29 term, with the UNGA voting scheduled for June 2027. Unlike India's previous eight terms won unopposed as a consensus choice, the current race is contested because Tajikistan is already the Asia-Pacific group's agreed candidate. The core issue is whether India's size, economy, and Council record should override the tradition of favoring first-time small countries, particularly within the Global South.

The Hindu

GS3 Himanshu: Step up job generation through India's rural employment guarantee scheme

The editorial argues that India must increase spending on its rural employment guarantee scheme to relieve rural distress and support the broader economy. One of the few high-frequency indicators of the rural economy's health is wages. Unfortunately, the signs aren't good.

Mint

GS3 A global mission LiFE: Mitigation potential of behavioural change in passenger transport in G20 Countries

Systemic decarbonisation requires behavioural change, as highlighted by the IPCC and UNEP, particularly within the passenger transport sector. Most nationally determined contributions currently fail to explicitly incorporate behavioural mitigation strategies or systematically quantify them. India launched the Mission Lifestyle for Environment at COP26 in 2021, followed by the 2023 G20 High Level Principles on Lifestyles for Sustainable Development. G20 members account for 84% of global GDP, 60% of the world population, and 78% of global CO2 emissions as of 2024.

Hindustan Times

GS2 Pakistan's Mecca Pact ambition has a problem—too many fronts, too little room

Pakistan signed the Makkah Pact in August alongside Saudi Arabia and Türkiye to move towards collective defence commitments and rapid military deployment. The pact faces immediate tests as Houthi drone and missile attacks repeatedly target Saudi airports, including Riyadh's King Khalid International Airport and Dammam's King Fahd International Airport. The core issue is whether Pakistan can limit its role to defensive assistance or risk being drawn into a wider regional conflict against the Houthis in Yemen.

ThePrint

GS3 Crunched commissions: India's new insurance rules have prompted a basic rethink of the sector's economics

The insurance regulator's new proposals on expense caps have forced companies to re-evaluate their business models. New regulatory proposals by the insurance watchdog require companies to lower their expense ratios to 12.5%, forcing a major rethink of sector economics. Insurers will need to adapt to the insurance regulator's proposals or risk staring at obsolescence. With running costs already at 6-28% of premium value, it will take a major rejig to achieve a 12.5% expense ratio while absorbing servicing costs.

Mint

GS2 GS3 Protect patients and patents smartly

The editorial discusses balancing cancer drug affordability with pharmaceutical patent protection using direct benefit transfers instead of overriding patent laws. The Kerala High Court has stressed the importance of making cancer medicines like ribociclib more affordable for patients. The Government of India is urged to refrain from using the Patents Act, as it could stifle pharmaceutical innovation. Instead, by utilizing the Aadhaar-based Direct Benefit Transfer system, it can offer financial assistance to those in need.

Economic Times

GS2 Livelihood scheme for women deserves better

The Centre allowed its flagship urban livelihoods scheme, DAY-NULM, to lapse without a successor, raising concerns among policy watchers. Since its 2014 launch, DAY-NULM helped create 10.02 lakh self-help groups covering over one crore urban women. Five states including Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh and Tripura have flagged funding concerns and the policy vacuum. Allowing the scheme to lapse risks leaving women beneficiaries adrift without continued support for institutional credit and bank linkages.

msn.com

GS2 In Trump-Putin deal, a message for Europe, India

US President Donald Trump struck a deal with Russian President Vladimir Putin to release Russian diesel supplies into global markets. This deal comes less than a month after the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026 was signed into law. While Trump claims the goal is to lower diesel prices for Americans and the world, analysts note midterm elections are less than three weeks away.

msn.com

GS2 Pump price before politics: Is Trump's Russian diesel purchase a necessary compromise or blatant hypocrisy?

Recent actions by Donald Trump to secure Russian diesel imports highlight the complexities of US energy policy, balancing domestic fuel prices against geopolitical strategies. Despite urging allies not to buy Russian oil, the US continues to navigate a delicate landscape where affordable fuel remains a political priority ahead of the midterm elections.

Economic Times

GS3 Eyes now on Viksit, net zero later :Can India achieve high-income status by 2047 without compromising on climate promises?

India aspires to achieve high-income status by 2047, which the World Bank estimates requires sustaining a 7.8% average GDP growth rate for over two decades. The author argues that India's net-zero by 2070 climate promise works at cross-purposes with the Viksit Bharat ambition, bringing high costs and lower growth. NITI Aayog's report 'Scenarios Towards Viksit Bharat and Net Zero' estimates that reaching carbon neutrality by 2070 will cost India $8.1 trillion in additional investments.

Economic Times

GS1 GS3 India's most undervalued agricultural asset: Women farmers

Women form the backbone of rural Indian agriculture, managing crops, livestock, natural resources, and household nutrition across the value chain. Indian agriculture faces severe climate variability, rising input costs, labor shortages, and resource constraints requiring all available talent. Despite their massive contribution, women farmers face uneven land ownership, difficult credit access, and poorly targeted extension services. The International Day of Rural Women and the UN's International Year of the Woman Farmer in 2026 demand moving beyond mere recognition to action.

Hindustan Times

GS3 India's China+1 lessons lie within its own States

Global firms shifting out of China select specific Indian States rather than treating the country as a single monolithic market. Tamil Nadu and Karnataka serve as internal role models due to decades of preparation in industrial ecosystems rather than foreign models like Vietnam. Tamil Nadu leverages deep automotive and technical education roots seen in Foxconn at Sriperumbudur and Tata Electronics at Hosur. Karnataka uses its engineering and software talent base, hosting Foxconn at Devanahalli and Tata Electronics at Narsapura.

The Hindu

GS2 India's decentralisation push needs stronger state finance commissions

India has spent over three decades building local government architecture through the 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendments, but decentralisation remains unfinished. The core problem is a weak institutional chain for devolving resources, responsibilities, and accountability, rather than just a lack of funding. The Sixteenth Finance Commission highlights that many states fail to constitute State Finance Commissions on time, weakening fiscal devolution. Available SFC reports vary considerably in methodology, coverage, and quality, making it difficult for successive Finance Commissions to use them.

ThePrint

GS3 Early Diwali dhamaka: With the IDBI strategic sale to Fairfax, GoI has taken a giant step in the disinvestment pathway

The strategic sale of IDBI Bank to Fairfax has put the government's disinvestment pathway in the news as an early Diwali development. The Government of India has proceeded with the strategic sale of IDBI Bank to Fairfax, netting twenty-six thousand crore rupees while retaining a fifteen percent stake. IDBI Bank's sale as part of a disinvestment strategy provides Rs. 26,000 cr to the government during economic challenges. Government of India retains a 15% stake, indicating potential future market sales.

Economic Times

GS2 Double standards: On the Trump diesel deal with Russia

The discussion arises from reported diesel deals involving Donald Trump and Russia, exposing Western hypocrisy. The editorial critiques the United States for maintaining double standards by criticizing developing nations for trading with Russia while pursuing its own diesel deals. The United States must stop moralising to the Global South for trading with Russia

The Hindu

GS3 How to turn overseas green regulation into export advantage

Green trade rules are a lasting feature of export markets rather than temporary trade irritants to negotiate away. Building India's future infrastructure around fossil fuels risks high replacement costs later given the 2070 net-zero target. Regulated foreign markets can help subsidize the early higher costs of cleaner technologies as India builds scale. India has secured some of the world's lowest prices for green ammonia, allowing long-term export contracts with Europe, Japan, and Korea.

civilsdaily.com

GS3 IDBI, poster boy for more privatisation

IDBI Bank has been sold to Fairfax, shifting the bank from government control to private ownership following years of recovery from bad loans. This sale follows a long period of bank recovery from bad loans and recapitalisation efforts. The new management faces challenges in driving IDBI Bank's growth in a competitive private banking environment. Foreign interest in India's banking sector continues to rise, influencing the strategic sale approach.

Economic Times

GS2 Why the EU may want Britain back in a changing geopolitical landscape

Shifting global alliances and regional security concerns have brought discussions regarding the future of EU-UK relations back into focus. The editorial analyzes the evolving geopolitical factors that could prompt the European Union to desire Britain's return. Why the EU may want Britain back

Deccan Herald

GS1 GS2 Satyagraha for Constitution-as-commons

Citizens taking to the streets to protest and invoke constitutional values in their fight for popular sovereignty. An opinion piece discussing how contemporary public protests utilize Gandhian principles and constitutional ideals to reclaim democratic control. The resisters out on the streets today are those who hold Gandhi's talisman and Ambedkar's Preamble in their fight to restore to the people of this country control over their lives

The Hindu

EXPLAINED

The concept behind the news, one or two lines each.

Women Livelihood – Significance & Challenges Women's livelihood acts as a primary driver for economic empowerment, gender equality, poverty reduction, and inclusive growth in India. The lapse of the Centre's flagship urban livelihood scheme, DAY-NULM, without a successor raises serious concerns regarding continuous institutional support.

ForumIAS

Why NITI Aayog wants stricter power, water checks before approving data centres The rapid proliferation of data centres and their high demand for electricity and water has raised sustainability concerns, prompting policy intervention. NITI Aayog has recommended enforcing stricter power and water consumption audits and checks before approving new data centres to ensure resource sustainability.

Indian Express

The Kigali Amendment at 10: Why India's cooling choices matter The milestone tenth anniversary of the Kigali Amendment brings focus to hydrofluorocarbons and India's cooling sector transitions. This explainer details the significance of the Kigali Amendment at its tenth anniversary and why India's cooling strategies are critical for global climate goals.
Indian Express

Why SC held that conversion to Islam alone does not qualify a person for BC reservation The Supreme Court held that a person converting to Islam cannot claim reservation under the Muslim backward class category based on their former caste status. The ruling came on an appeal filed by the Tamil Nadu government against a Madras High Court order that quashed its decision recognizing seven backward class Muslim sects for converts.
newindianexpress.com

Why is there opposition against setting up foreign universities in Tamil Nadu? Explained Left parties and civic groups have opposed the approval, warning that it will lead to the commercialisation of higher education. The University of Western Australia has received final approval from the UGC to open a branch campus in Chennai.
The Hindu

West Asia conflict: Why Indian seafarers keep sailing into Hormuz The persistent security threats in West Asia have put the spotlight on the continued sailing of Indian merchant navy crews through the Strait of Hormuz. An explainer on why Indian seafarers continue to navigate through the high-risk Strait of Hormuz despite escalating conflicts in West Asia.
Indian Express

Mint Explainer: What do the GST Council's latest tax cuts mean for India's farmers? The recent announcements by the GST Council regarding tax cuts and exemptions for agricultural sectors put the issue in the news. The GST Council has introduced tax exemptions and rate reductions on key agricultural services and goods like seed storage, coffee curing, and retreaded tyres to reduce farmer operational costs.
Mint

What is the 90-day 'weeding out' period for NEET records, and why is the matter before SC? The Supreme Court agreed to urgently hear a NEET-UG 2026 candidate's petition challenging the authenticity of her OMR answer sheet. The petitioner Shreya Chaudhari feared that the National Testing Agency would destroy her original examination record once the retention period expired.
outlookindia.com

Wealthy countries' debt could be hurting economies like India. Here's what IMF suggests The report highlights growing concerns over macroeconomic stability as wealthy nations grapple with rising debt burdens. The IMF has warned that high public debt in advanced economies can adversely affect emerging markets like India through tighter financial conditions and capital outflows.
Indian Express

Explainer: Jaishankar's Africa Tour and India's Global South Strategy The high-level diplomatic visit highlights India's ongoing strategic focus on consolidating ties with the Global South. External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar undertakes a diplomatic tour to Africa to reinforce India's partnership with the continent.
India's World

SC order on train insurance: Who is eligible, and what compensation can you receive? The Supreme Court delivered a significant ruling clarifying train insurance eligibility and compensation norms. An explainer on the Supreme Court order detailing who is eligible for train insurance compensation and the amounts payable.
Indian Express

How is AI-MedTech in India regulated? CDSCO released guidelines on software and AI use in medical devices in July 2026. An explainer on the current regulatory status of AI-driven medical technology in India and the debate over the need for a statutory legal framework.
The Hindu

ALSO IN THE NEWS

Reactions, previews and smaller stories: one line each.

- MP Cabinet Approves Soybean Bhavantar Scheme and Economic Corridor Development (Agriculture & Allied) Indianmasterminds
- Vice-President inaugurates KAUMARACON-2026 and launches digital initiatives of the All India Institute of Ayurveda (Health) PIB
- Op Sindoor, Balakot Airstrike & Surgical Strike reflect India's shift from diplomatic condemnation to proactive action to eliminate terrorism at its source: Raksha Mantri (Internal Security) PIB
- India's unemployment rate remains stable at 5% in September: NSO data (Economy) Business Standard
- Union Minister for Finance & Corporate Affairs Smt. Nirmala Sitharaman participates in the 114th meeting of the Development Committee Plenary of the World Bank in Bangkok, Thailand, today (International Relations) PIB
- Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) and Central Bureau of Narcotics (CBN) destroy 2.87 Hectares (7.08 Acres) of illicit cannabis (ganja) cultivation in wildlife sanctuary, District Dhule, Maharashtra (Environment & Ecology) PIB
- NHAI Introduces Independent Checking of Designs of Major Bridges and Critical National Highway Structures (Infrastructure & Energy) PIB
- Jammu and Kashmir High Court bars use of shikara motorboats, jet skis on Dal lake in Srinagar (Environment & Ecology) The Hindu

- India Must Move from Being a Global Content Market to a Creator of Globally Competitive Media and Entertainment Companies: Secretary, I&B, at CII Big Picture Summit 2026 (Economy) PIB
- Bangladesh ranks 84th in Global Hunger Index 2026 (Social Justice & Welfare) The Financial Express
- Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act 2005, Provisions (Social Justice & Welfare) Vajiram & Ravi
- A global mission LiFE: Mitigation potential of behavioural change in passenger transport in G20 Countries (Environment & Ecology) Hindustan Times
- HDPT advocates UNESCO World Heritage recognition for Nallamala Sanctuary (Environment & Ecology) The Hindu
- Southwest monsoon withdraws from entire country: IMD (Geography) Hindustan Times
- Supreme Court Hearing on SIR Exercise, Election Commission Petitions and Protest Site (Polity & Constitution) India Today
- INDIA-US JOINT MILITARY EXERCISE YUDH ABHYAS 2026 COMMENCES AT AULI AND MAHAJAN (Defence) Press Information Bureau
- Shri Ravi Shanker Goel appointed as the next Ambassador of India to the Republic of Suriname (International Relations) Ministry of External Affairs
- First Joint View by Coronagraphs on India's Aditya-L1 and Europe's Proba-3 Decodes Solar Eruptions Near Their Birthplace (Science & Technology) ISRO
- Union Minister of Culture and Tourism Shri Gajendra Singh Shekhawat Inaugurates ‘TAKSHANAM’, An Exhibition Bringing Together 150 Artists and Over 250 Sculptures at NGMA (History, Art & Culture) PIB
- Distinguish between persuasion and manipulation from an ethical perspective. Identify the moral principles that should govern attempts to influence human behaviour. (Ethics & Integrity) Insights on India
- In 1998, India planned 24 submarines by 2030, currently it has 16 and newest submarines are years away (Defence) Economic Times
- Kigali Amendment: India’s Cooling Choices and Global Climate Goals (Environment & Ecology) Vajiram & Ravi
- IMF Raises India Growth Outlook To 7%, Backs Economic Resilience And Reforms (Economy) BW Businessworld
- Jaishankar pushes for 'reform of multilateralism' as India, UAE discuss ties amid West Asia tensions (International Relations) Firstpost
- Dalhousie University signs MoUs with IIT, IISER Tirupati (Education) The Hans India
- Tamil Nadu government fully prepared to face Northeast monsoon: Revenue Minister (Disaster Management) The Hindu
- Wholesale inflation hits series high of 11.4% in September as fuel, food prices surge (Economy) Economic Times
- Defence Minister Rajnath Singh to represent India at upcoming SCO Heads of Government meeting (International Relations) The Hindu
- When India said 'no' at WTO: A stand that still protects food security (Economy) Business Standard
- US Iran war: Tehran says oil tanker on fire in Strait of Hormuz (International Relations) Economic Times
- DRDO Warns India Risks Future War Failures Without Semiconductor Self-Reliance (Science & Technology) Convergence Now
- ‘Enlighten us’ on the prohibitory orders, preserve all CCTV footage: Supreme Court directs Centre, police (Polity & Constitution) The Hindu
- Supreme Court Tightens Safeguards on Arrest (Polity & Constitution) Vajiram & Ravi
- How can India’s Chief Election Commissioner be removed? Rules and provisions explained (Polity & Constitution) Organiser
- Supreme Court seeks Centre’s response on plea to hold protest organisers liable for damage (Polity & Constitution) Times of India
- Intra-Court Appeal Against Contempt Orders Can’t Be Barred Merely by Calling Proceedings Criminal: Supreme Court (Polity & Constitution) Juris Hour
- Integrated Logistics for India’s Theatre Commands: Key Reforms (Defence) Indian Express
- India's Skyroot Bags Major Private US Contract After Vikram-1 Launch Success (Science & Technology) NDTV
- ‘Process cannot become punishment’: SC warns against indefinite jail before trial (Polity & Constitution) Hindustan Times
- Menstrual Hygiene A Fundamental Right: Supreme Court Warns States Of Contempt Over Non-Implementation Of... (Social Justice & Welfare) Live Law
- Humanity has crossed 7 major climate tipping points. But there's still hope (Environment & Ecology) India Today
- SC: Tough PMLA bail conditions can't override accused's right (Polity & Constitution) Times of India
- Telecom operators to show KYC name of incoming callers from November 1 (Governance & Policy) The Hindu
- Pak Drone Drop: Rajasthan Cops Suspected Drugs, Found Ready-To-Use Bomb (Internal Security) NDTV
- SC: Cops can’t seek digital footprints for roving probe (Polity & Constitution) Times of India
- Living Will in India: Supreme Court Guidelines, Passive Euthanasia & Right to Die with Dignity (Polity & Constitution) Legal Service India
- First tranche of US trade deal ready: Commerce Minister (International Relations) BusinessLine
- India's Hunger Score Improves, But Child 'Wasting' Remains High (Social Justice & Welfare) NDTV
- BT Explainer: What is BS-VII, what changes does the draft propose, and how could it impact vehicle manufacturers and buyers? (Environment & Ecology) Business Today

COVERAGE CHECK

Items — 17 must-know, 19 Prelims facts, 49 in the news, 22 editorials, 12 explainers.

Syllabus areas in the cards — Economy (12), Governance & Policy (8), Polity & Constitution (6), Environment & Ecology (5), Defence (2), International Relations (2), Science & Technology (1). **Nothing today in —** Social Justice & Welfare, Health, Education, Agriculture &

Allied, Infrastructure & Energy, Internal Security, Disaster Management, History, Art & Culture, Geography, Society, Ethics & Integrity.

Easy-miss watch — Marine & coastal (EEZ, UNCLOS, Blue Economy, deep sea): nothing today · Digital Public Infrastructure & data governance: 1 · Political change in the neighbourhood: nothing today · Appointments to constitutional / statutory / regulatory bodies: 1 · Defence-technology cooperation agreements: 1

Full text — 40 of 70 items were read in full from a free copy; the rest are summarised from the outlets' reports. Subscriber-only sites are never opened.

Sources in the cards — The Hindu 14, PIB 8, Economic Times 7, Mint 5, Indian Express 5, msn.com 3, Hindustan Times 3, newindianexpress.com 3, ForumIAS 2, Business Standard 2, Bar & Bench 2, ThePrint 2, Vajiram & Ravi 1, timesofindia.indiatimes.com 1

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